

Because Dreaming Costs Money: The Price of Social Mobility in Chimamanda Ngozi Adichie's "Apollo"

Everything comes with a price, even a dream. In "Apollo," by Chimamanda Ngozi Adichie, a Nigerian man named Okenwa visiting his parents reminisces about his childhood and an old houseboy named Raphael. Okenwa and Raphael were close as children, but the former ultimately got him fired, catalyzing the latter's turn to crime that culminated in his imprisonment. Through the use of symbolism, metaphor, and tone in "Apollo," Adichie suggests that the ability to dream beyond things considered ordinary is limited by class. Moreover, Adichie argues that the fundamental reasons for this disparity are that class restricts aspirations and risk-taking as well as the ability to commit to a dream.

By using symbolism in tandem with dialogue, Chimamanda Ngozi Adichie illustrates how Okenwa is able to aspire towards being like Bruce Lee — the personification of his dreams — while Raphael is grounded in his more harsh reality. When Okenwa thinks, "This truly was happening. I could become a black belt one day," he rejoices, fantasizing about trying a flying kick off a veranda (Adichie 5). However, his aspirations are cast off by Raphael's curt reply: "No... That veranda is too high (Adichie 5)." The phrase "this was truly happening" displays Okenwa's dreams and aspirations. He is in a blissful moment of realization, but Raphael shoots him down. Adichie emphasizes the height of the veranda, which Raphael points out. She symbolizes the idea of division with this height: Okenwa is prepared to ascend, but Raphael is physically and figuratively grounded. Adichie repeats the motif of Okenwa fantasizing about being a martial artist and Raphael rejecting those fantasies throughout the story. When Okenwa remarks, "I wish I had a nunchaku," Raphael immediately replies, "It is very difficult to use," again diminishing Okenwa's dream with a clipped reply (Adichie 6). After this, Okenwa "felt almost sorry to have wanted one" (Adichie 6). Once more, Okenwa sees a material manifestation of his dream and latches onto it, but Raphael is steadfast. He understands the danger and difficulty of using a nunchaku, while Okenwa is ignorant of that. The detail that Okenwa "felt almost sorry to have wanted one" illustrates his realization of his ignorance. He feels guilty for so easily gravitating to an idea that is completely out of reach for Raphael. His houseboy realizes the near-impossibility of Okenwa's dream, and so when he makes a nunchaku by himself, he understands that it is simply for fun. Part of Raphael's purpose in making it was to prove Okenwa wrong, showing that he couldn't just pick up the nunchaku and successfully use it. Furthermore, Okenwa "almost" feeling sorry suggests that he is ignorant of the true ramifications of Raphael's class — he sees the physical manifestations of it (not being able to freely follow his dreams), but fails to acknowledge the harsh reality of Raphael's work, which is to be constantly subservient to one that should be a peer. This symbolism cements the pattern of Okenwa wanting to take risks to do what he loves, while Raphael is much more reserved in his aspirations.

Adichie furthers the idea of class restricting social mobility by using tone and metaphor to show how Raphael is unable to commit to his dreams as much as Okenwa is. Raphael views playing with Okenwa as a respite from his otherwise grueling job, while Okenwa feels the

opposite way. He narrates, “It was after school, with Raphael, that my real life began” (Adichie, 6). At this time in his life, Okenwa’s main focus is his martial arts dream—it is his “real life.” He is enamored with the idea of Bruce Lee and martial arts, idealizing them in the process. Thus, he is ignorant of the less glamorous parts of his dream. However, for Raphael, martial arts are simply a way to cope with his already difficult job. He enjoys it, but in the end, his priority is his work. When Okenwa’s parents perceive Raphael as “part of the landscape outside: weeding the garden, washing pots at the water tank,” he is distilled down to menial labor (Adichie, 6). Okenwa questions this framing of Raphael, but it is ultimately true. He is relegated to a subordinate position; Raphael serves Okenwa’s family, and while he and Okenwa develop a relationship, his job is at stake with every one of their interactions. Raphael hangs out with Okenwa not just because they were friends, but also because he has to: if Okenwa were to complain to his parents about Raphael, he would be swiftly replaced. Adichie’s tone almost objectifies Raphael—he is seen as literally “part of the landscape.” Moreover, he is physically separated from the family by being “outside” in the heat, unlike Okenwa’s parents, who are in the cool comfort of their home. These details exemplify the tone of Adichie’s writing and illustrate the true weight of Raphael’s employment and status.

Throughout “Apollo,” Chimamanda Ngozi Adichie illustrates how class limits the ability to strive for the “extraordinary.” The disparities Adichie describes are not unique to the story: people, especially in the global south, are often forced into harsh jobs as laborers for which they are undervalued and underpaid. Some, like Raphael, are forced to turn to crime to stay alive and are punished for that decision. However, the system that criminalized these people in the first place does not change. Raphael, and countless teenagers like him, are trapped in a pipeline that ends in incarceration or death.